

Sales Training — Session 38

Not a Priority. Never Will Be.

Closing the Silent-Killer Website Objection.

Thursday 18 June 2026 · Marketing Sweet

WHAT THIS SESSION IS How to handle one of the most common objections on the phone — the successful tradie or trade business owner who agrees their website is bad, agrees they should do something about it, and tells the rep it isn't a priority right now. The agree-first move, the silent-killer frame, the under-quote trick that surfaces the real cost, the nudging words, and the locksmith mindset that ties it all together.

1. The objection that derails most website pitches

Almost every rep meets this objection in the first ten calls of any day on the website desk. The buyer has a successful trade business. The work is coming through referrals and word of mouth. They acknowledge — often disarmingly — that their website is bad. They've been meaning to do something about it. It's just not a priority right now, and the rep can hear in the buyer's voice that it hasn't been a priority for a long time.

Most reps respond by trying to convince the buyer that the website matters. They push harder on the value of a good site. They try to manufacture urgency. They end up sounding like every other website salesperson the buyer has fobbed off this year, and the call ends. The session's central claim is that the standard response is wrong — the right move starts with agreeing, but agreeing in a very specific direction.

"This is one of the fun parts of my job. Everyone who tells me websites aren't a priority right now never does anything about it ever. I'm not trying to pressure you — but you need to do something."

2. Agree first — "never will be" is the unlock

The first words out of the rep's mouth, every time, are the same: "I totally understand." From there, instead of pivoting to value, the rep takes the buyer's objection further than the buyer did. "I understand it's not a priority. And to be honest with you — based on the experience we have in this industry — it never will be a priority."

That sentence does the work. The buyer was prepared to defend "not now." They have no defensive script ready for "never." The rep has just removed the buyer's most reliable exit — "I'll do it later" — by gently pointing out that later doesn't actually arrive. People only get concerned about their health when they have a health problem; people only get concerned about their website when something forces them to. Left alone, the website slides down the list every single quarter, every single year, indefinitely.

"I understand it's not a priority. And I also understand — it never will be. People only get concerned about their health when they've got a health problem. Websites work the same way."

The buyer's response to this is almost always a beat of silence followed by some version of "yeah, you're probably right." They're not being convinced. They're agreeing. From that moment, the conversation is no longer about whether to do something about the website — it's about when. That's the conversation the rep wants to be in.

3. The silent killer / silent winner frame

Once the buyer has agreed that the website is a problem, the rep introduces the central conceptual frame of the call. Websites are unusual in that they're both a silent winner and a silent killer. Silent winner: when the website is good, every referral that lands on it confirms the buyer's reputation and converts to a job, and the buyer never finds out their website did anything — they just keep getting referrals. Silent killer: when the website is bad, every referral that lands on it leaves without calling, and the buyer never finds out THAT either — those referrals just quietly don't ring.

This invisibility is what makes the objection so sticky. Buyers don't have a feedback loop that tells them how many people checked them out, didn't like what they saw, and went elsewhere. They feel busy. They feel referred. They don't feel the leak. The rep's job is to make the leak visible — without overclaiming, without bullying, just by walking through the obvious logic the buyer hasn't yet walked through.

"Websites are a silent killer and a silent winner. The issue is there's no way to measure the referrals that aren't calling you. There's no evidence of the leak — and that's why the leak persists."

4. The guarantee — "you're losing money"

After the silent-killer frame, the rep makes one of the few real guarantees they ever make on a call. "I can't guarantee many things. But I can guarantee you that right now, you're losing money to your website. I'm guaranteeing that." The word "guarantee" is unusual in sales precisely because it's so often hollow. Used here — sparingly, on a claim that's actually defensible — it lands.

Why it's defensible: any referral-driven business in 2026 has referrals checking the website. Some of those referrals don't like what they see. Some of those referrals don't call. The buyer can't measure how many, but the rep doesn't need to measure how many — they only need the buyer to acknowledge that the number is greater than zero. Once it's greater than zero, multiplied by the average job value (next section), the loss is real and the rep can quantify it.

"I can guarantee you it's costing you money. Because referrals are coming to you, and the issue is there's no way to measure the amount of referrals that aren't calling you."

5. Deliberately under-quote — the \$5,000 trick

The most useful tactical move in the session. Once the rep has the guarantee in place, they reach for a number to make the loss feel real. They deliberately under-quote the buyer's likely average job value. Something like: "and let's say your average job is worth, what — about \$5,000? Just one referral that didn't call you because your website looked dated. That's \$5,000 gone."

The buyer's automatic reaction — for anyone in a high-value trade like building, renovations, or kitchen work — is to correct upward. "\$5,000? No mate, my average job is more like \$20,000." That correction is the whole point of the move. The rep didn't need to know the real number. They needed the buyer to volunteer it, in a moment of mild irritation that they were being undervalued. Now the loss isn't "some unspecified amount." It's \$20,000 per referral that didn't call — and the buyer just said that out loud.

"I'd say your average job is probably \$5,000. He'll go: 'mate, it's way more than that.' Bang. I've now got him saying his loss is bigger than I claimed. I never had to argue the number."

Two extensions of the same trick — used together they create a compounding effect. Get the website's age slightly wrong: "when's the last time you had this built — five years ago?" Most older sites are 10–20 years old, and the buyer will correct. Get the rebuild frequency wrong in the other direction: "this needs doing every five years probably." The buyer will agree, which means they now believe their site is overdue. Three small under-estimates, three corrections from the buyer, and the rep has built the case for action without ever pushing it.

6. "Most" and "generally" — the nudging words

Two power words worth treating as core toolkit. "Most." "Generally." Both are nudgers — they create soft confidence without arrogant absolutes. "All clients" or "every business" sets up an argument the rep can lose if the buyer can think of a single counterexample. "Most" can't be argued with. "Generally" can't be argued with. They convey the same authority with none of the brittleness.

Use cases the session worked through:

- "Most successful trade businesses get their work from referrals." Buyer will agree.
- "Most people who say it's not a priority never end up doing anything about it." Buyer will laugh — and agree.
- "Generally, when a buyer says websites aren't important, what they really mean is they don't want to spend money." Buyer will reluctantly agree.
- "Most household buying decisions are made by women." The trade buyer will agree with surprising conviction.

The restaurant analogy makes the principle stick. A waiter who says "most people order the rib-eye tonight" gets significantly higher rib-eye orders than a waiter who says nothing. The

customer isn't being manipulated — they're being nudged in a direction with a phrase that's polite, low-pressure, and almost impossible to push back on without sounding contrarian.

"Most" and "generally" are your three screwdrivers in the toolbox. They tweak, they don't hammer. Use them everywhere — every pitch, every objection."

7. The toolbox phrases — memorise verbatim

Beyond the nudgers, the session named several phrases the rep should keep in instant recall and use verbatim:

- "Whether with us or someone else — you need to do something." Removes sales pressure. Positions the rep as honest broker rather than vendor.
- "Definitely less expensive than you think." Pre-empts the cost objection without naming a number.
- "Can I please explain to you why..." — a soft permission ask that almost always gets a yes, and gives the rep a window to deliver the next move.
- "You should be more scared of what you're losing." Reframes the cost — they're not scared of paying, they're scared of paying for the WRONG thing. The real cost is the loss they can't see.
- "This is the front of house of your business — like all your machinery, it needs to be maintained." Tradies respect maintenance. The frame lands.

These aren't tricks. They're calibrated language that the team has tested across hundreds of calls. Each one earns its place. Reps who memorise them and reach for them automatically close materially more often than reps who improvise. Print them on a card. Keep them next to the phone.

8. The grudge purchase — why this objection is structural

A reframe that helps the rep understand WHY the buyer is dragging their feet. Some purchases are pleasurable — new shoes, a new car, a holiday. The buyer enjoys the shopping, enjoys the spending, enjoys the having. Other purchases are grudge purchases. Tyres. Insurance. Plumbing repairs. Roof restoration. Websites. The buyer doesn't enjoy any part of these — they only do them when they have to.

Grudge purchases get procrastinated by default. The buyer's brain treats them the same way it treats cleaning the gutters — important, never urgent, easy to push off another month. This is structural, not a personal failing of any one buyer. The rep can't change the fact that websites are a grudge purchase. What the rep CAN do is acknowledge it out loud — which disarms the buyer instantly. "I know how you feel about this — nobody gets excited about building a website. It's a grudge purchase. It costs money. The process is usually awful." The buyer feels heard. The wall comes down.

"I know how you feel about this — it's a grudge purchase. No one gets excited about building a website. Costs money. The process is usually awful. The exciting part for me is what happens AFTER it's done."

9. The bald tyre — a grudge analogy tradies understand

A specific image that lands hard with the trade audience. "Imagine I pointed at your car and told you one of your tyres is bald — needs replacing. What would you say to me?" The buyer's response is reliably "yeah, I know, I've been meaning to deal with it." That's the exact same response they're giving the rep about the website. The frame makes the parallel obvious.

The buyer knows they need new tyres. They know the tyres are dangerous. They know the cost of NOT replacing them — a blowout, a tow truck, a much bigger bill — is greater than the cost of replacing them. They still procrastinate, because tyres are a grudge purchase and the consequence isn't visible yet. The website is the same. The bald tyre is leaking referrals every week. The buyer can't see it. But the leak is happening, and the longer it goes on, the more expensive the consequences.

"Your website is a bald tyre. You know it. I know it. We both know what happens if you leave it. The only question is whether we fix it before the blowout or after."

10. Two pain points — attack process, not price

A diagnostic that sharpens the pitch. Buyers who hesitate on a website rebuild are weighing two pain points: money and process. The rep has very little room to move on the money side — the agency's prices are what they are. The rep has enormous room to move on the process side — and that's where the agency's actual advantage lives.

Most buyers who've built a website before had a nightmare experience. The provider was disorganised. The buyer ended up doing half the work themselves. Deadlines slipped. The content came back wrong. The design came back wrong. It dragged on for six months. The cost wasn't just dollars — it was hours of the buyer's life. When the rep brings this up, the buyer will recognise it immediately and start nodding.

"Most people I speak to who've built a website before describe it as a nightmare. The cool thing is, our process is the best in the industry. Taylor virtually does everything for you. One meeting, you say yes or no to what she presents. That's it."

The rep should attack process, not price. Price defends itself when the buyer trusts the process. Price loses every time when the buyer doesn't. This is also why the rep needs to KNOW the process — see Section 12. Bluffing the process gets caught. Genuinely understanding it produces conviction that the buyer can feel.

11. The kitchen-maker story — what the silent killer actually costs

A concrete worked example from Corie's own life. His cousin needed a new kitchen — budget around \$100,000. Corie's friend, a builder, referred his cousin to a specific kitchen-maker. Strong endorsement. The cousin rang the kitchen-maker, who was abrupt and didn't have a website. The cousin couldn't get a sense of who the business was, what their previous work looked like, or whether they were credible. The cousin went elsewhere. The kitchen-maker lost a \$100,000 job.

Corie later rang the kitchen-maker to explain what had happened — that the website (or absence of one) was the reason the deal didn't close. The kitchen-maker bristled: "if a client judges me on a website, I don't want that kind of client." Ego masquerading as principle. The \$7,000 website would have closed the \$100,000 deal. The kitchen-maker chose his pride over the deal — and, the story ends, the business closed a few years later.

"He turned down a \$7,000 website that would have closed a \$100,000 kitchen. He told me he didn't want those kinds of clients. He's out of business now. The website is a silent killer."

The story works in the pitch because it's specific, it's personal, and the numbers are stark. \$7k versus \$100k isn't a hypothetical loss — it's a ratio that any tradie understands instantly. When the buyer hears it, the calculation in their head changes. They stop thinking about the cost of the website and start thinking about the cost of NOT having one. That's the moment the deal moves.

12. Learning is earning — know the product or lose the pitch

A different layer of the same lesson. The rep can't pitch the website build process with conviction if they don't actually know it. Most reps haven't sat in on a full build, haven't watched Taylor present a draft, haven't seen the seven-step process end to end. They pitch it generically — "our process is great" — and the buyer hears the generic and discounts it. Specifics are credibility. "It's great" isn't a specific.

Compare two ways of describing a girlfriend. "She's nice" tells you nothing — the speaker hasn't actually thought about who she is. "Caring, understanding, passionate, driven" tells you the speaker knows her. Same person; completely different signal about how well the speaker understands her. The agency's services are the same. The rep who can describe the seven-step build process by memory has done the work. The rep who says "our process is great" hasn't, and the buyer can hear the gap.

"What do you love about our website build process? 'The seven-step process — Taylor's design phase — the way she manages content collection.' That's recall. 'It's great' is hope."

Practical move: every rep should be able to walk a buyer through the agency's build process in 90 seconds without notes. If they can't, that's the homework. Sit in on Taylor's process. Watch a build from kickoff to launch. Take notes. Get specific. The conviction follows the knowledge; conviction can't precede it.

13. The locksmith — closing image

Corie's closing metaphor for the rep's whole job. Selling is like picking locks. The rep is a locksmith. Every prospect is a different lock. Some locks have nothing inside — no deal there, no matter how skilfully the rep picks them. Some locks have deals inside, and getting to them requires the right combination of tools used in the right order. The wrong tools used on a deal-lock damage the lock and lose the deal forever.

The tools are the moves in this playbook. The nudging words. The under-quote trick. The silent-killer frame. The "never will be" agreement. "Definitely less expensive than you think." The grudge-purchase reframe. The kitchen-maker story. Each one has a specific job. Each one fits a specific kind of lock. The rep who reaches for the right tool at the right moment opens locks. The rep who hammers at every lock with the same tool breaks them and walks away empty-handed.

"Selling is locksmithing. Some locks are empty. Some have a deal inside. The wrong tool on a deal-lock breaks it forever. Know your tools."

14. Action items for the team

1. Memorise the verbatim opener: "I totally understand. It's not a priority — and I'll be honest with you, it never will be a priority. People only get concerned about their health when they've got a health problem."
2. Practise the under-quote move on the next five calls. Drop a low average-job figure (\$5k) and watch the buyer correct upward. Note the number they volunteer.
3. Replace any sentence containing "all" or "every" with "most" or "generally." Do this for one week. Watch how it changes the buyer's resistance.
4. Print the toolbox phrases (Section 7) on a card and keep it next to the phone. Use "definitely less expensive than you think" and "whether with us or someone else" on every call this week.
5. Sit in on a full Taylor-led website build kickoff. Watch the seven-step process. Take notes. By end of the month, be able to walk a buyer through the process in 90 seconds without notes.
6. Memorise the kitchen-maker story verbatim — \$7k website, \$100k lost job, business closed. Use it on the next buyer who claims they don't need a website.
7. After every call, ask yourself: did I attack process or price? If the answer is price, you defended a battle the agency can't win. Process is where the agency's actual advantage lives.
8. When you find a buyer with a recent website from a competitor agency, flag it to Corie. The agency runs Bob's-marketing-style providers through a crawler and works the vein.

THE RULE OF THUMB Agree first — and take the agreement further than the buyer did. "Not a priority" → "never will be." Then make the silent killer visible. Under-quote the loss. Use

"most" and "generally" everywhere. Attack process, not price. The rep with the right tools opens the lock. The rep who hammers every lock breaks them all.